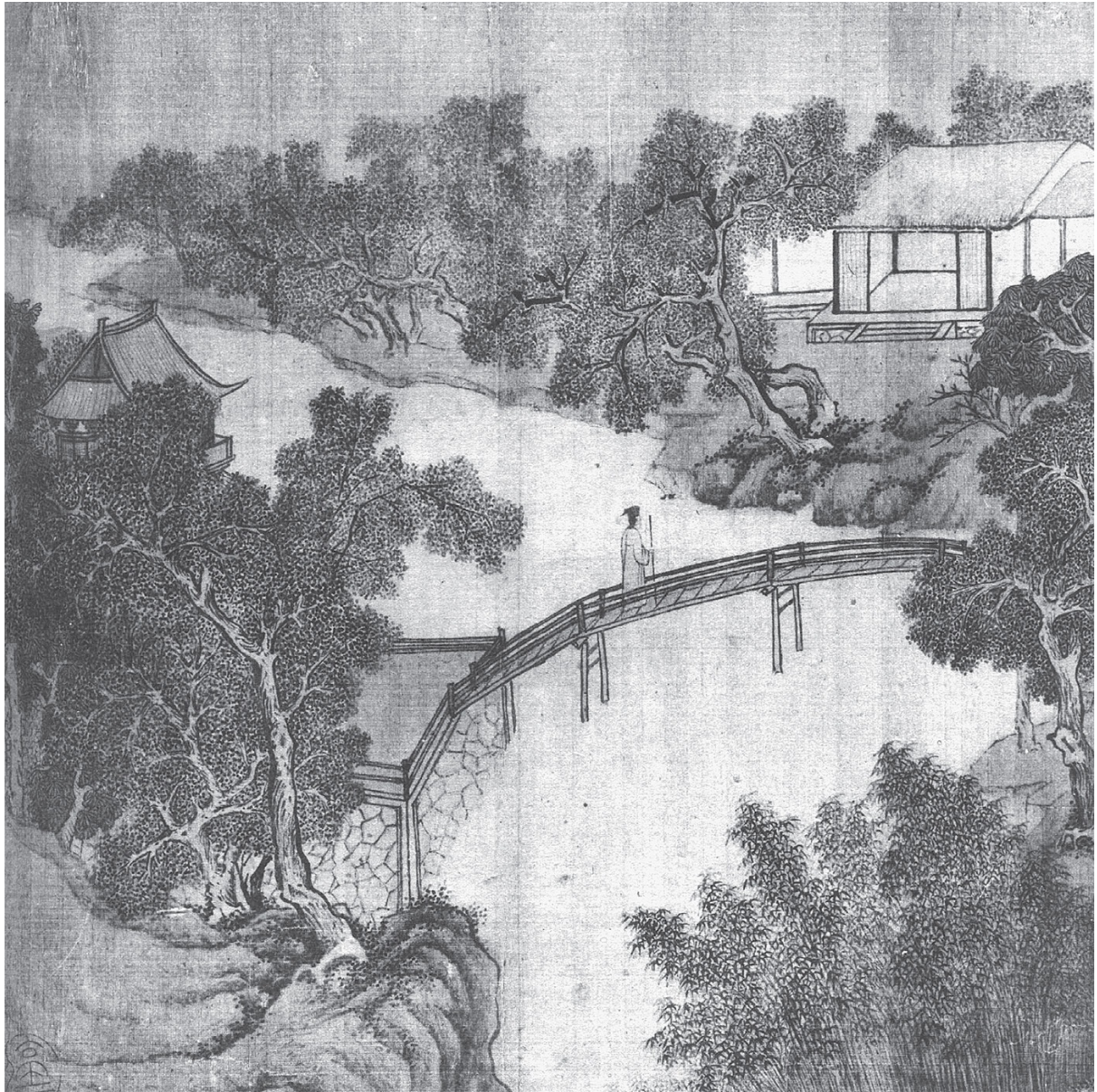


Chinese Ming Dynasty

After nearly a century of Mongol rule, the indigenous Ming Dynasty took control of China in 1368 and helped the country rise once more as a great power. The Forbidden City was built in Beijing, and artists were commissioned to portray the dynasty's generosity and grandeur. Old traditions were revived, and new skills, techniques and styles developed.

Paintings were delicate, comprising landscapes and figurative narratives, while calligraphy became expressive and closely integrated with painting. Ceramics became more sophisticated, with blue and white ware and cloisonné inspired by Islamic art through China's flourishing trade links. A Bureau of Design maintained standards of decoration on ceramics, textiles and other objects. Individual painters were skilled in a range of techniques, but the Wu School of artists were particularly adept in the 'Three Perfections' of poetry, calligraphy and painting, led by Four Great Masters, Shen Zhou (1427–1509), Wen Zhengming (1470–1559), Tang Yin (1470–1524) and Qiu Ying (1494–1552).



Wen Zhengming, *Landscape of the Humble Administrator's Garden*, 1533